not anyone who was half as good as Parthasarathy and me when it came to a game of cards.

In bridge, not having the right partner—as is the case with space science—can be irritating, and the game can end with some very bad blood. It happened to me when my bridge partner was the wife of a senior employee. In the game, one needs to give enough hints to the partner about his deck of cards without exposing anything to the rivals. This woman knew nothing about this trick, and remained tight-lipped through the game, thereby not allowing me to win though I had a great set of cards.

Parthasarathy, who was not playing but was looking at my cards, said, 'Nambi, you have a great set, why don't you close the deal.' I could have, but for the partner's inability. I retorted: 'I can close, but she is not opening her mouth.'

It was a straight forward comment which the woman mistook, probably for a double entendre, and made a big issue out of it. 'You don't know how to speak in the presence of a woman,' she screamed. I was stunned. I politely asked Parthasarathy what wrong had I done. Knowing the woman's temper, Parthasarathy patted me. 'Don't bother, let's leave the place,' he said.

This camaraderie did not reflect in Parthasarathy's attitude towards me at work where he continued to discourage me. Eighteen months after I joined the sugar factory, sometime in August 1966, I got a telegram from home: MOTHER SERIOUS. START IMMEDIATELY. Bored as I was with the routine, and this was a valid reason to apply for leave, but Parthasarathy would not grant me leave. I explained that my mother was unwell, I pleaded, but the boss would have none of it. I walked out of his room, got a paper from his personal assistant sitting outside his office, and wrote my resignation letter. I re-entered the room and gave the folded paper to Parthasarathy.

'I said you are not going,' he continued shouting. 'Now take back that leave letter.' I told him it was not a leave letter, it was my resignation. Parthasarathy sat frozen. My leaving the job would be a double whammy for him: He would lose a qualified engineer on the floor; if I mention to the